

DOCTRINAL PREACHING

Preaching the Great Truths of the Faith So People Can Hear, Understand, and Live Them

Wayne Cook, Th.D.
Author and General Editor
Chapala Theological Seminary
CTS Textbook Edition 2026.1

1. Doctrine Must Preach

Doctrine is not a warehouse of religious facts. Christian doctrine is the church's disciplined attempt to say truthfully what Scripture teaches about God, humanity, Christ, salvation, the Spirit, the church, and the future. Doctrinal preaching brings those truths into the pulpit so that people can understand, believe, worship, and live them.

A doctrinal sermon is therefore not a theology lecture with a closing illustration. It begins with biblical truth, develops that truth clearly, and drives toward response. The preacher asks not only, 'Is this accurate?' but also, 'Why does this matter to these people now?'

Preaching is a divine-human event: God's truth comes through a human voice. The Bible itself is divinely inspired and written through human authors; Christ is fully divine and fully human. The preacher does not create revelation, but faithfully gives voice to what God has revealed.

2. From Text to Doctrine

Sound doctrine must arise from Scripture rather than being imposed upon it. A single text may state a doctrine directly, contribute one part of it, or need to be read alongside other passages.

The doctrinal preacher moves in both directions: from particular texts toward the church's larger understanding, and from that larger understanding back to texts that must govern it. Systematic theology is useful precisely because Scripture speaks about the same realities in many places.

Proof-texting becomes dangerous when verses are detached from context merely because they contain desired words. A doctrinal sermon should show hearers why the texts actually support the claim being preached.

3. Preaching the Doctrine of Revelation and Scripture

Christian preaching begins with the conviction that God has spoken. General revelation displays God's power and glory in creation; special revelation makes known truths we could not discover adequately by observing nature alone. Scripture gives the church its authoritative written witness.

Inspiration does not erase human authorship. God used vocabulary, personality, history, genre, and circumstance. The divine-human character of Scripture means careful interpretation is an act of respect, not distrust.

A sermon on Scripture should do more than defend a doctrine of the Bible. It should create hunger to hear and obey the Word. If people leave knowing the term 'inspiration' but with no greater desire to listen to God, the doctrine has been accurately named but incompletely preached.

4. Preaching the Doctrine of God

Doctrine of God sermons must resist reducing God to one attribute. Scripture speaks of holiness and love, justice and mercy, transcendence and nearness, sovereignty and faithfulness. These truths do not compete within God.

The Trinity is not an arithmetic puzzle to be solved by clever analogies. Christians confess one God in three Persons—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit—because Scripture drives the church toward that confession. Most popular analogies eventually mislead if pressed too far.

Preach God's attributes toward worship and trust. Omnipotence matters when the congregation feels helpless. Faithfulness matters when promises seem delayed. Holiness exposes sin; grace gives sinners hope. Doctrine becomes proclamation when the hearer sees what the truth means before God.

5. Preaching the Doctrine of Humanity and Sin

Genesis 1:26–27 gives human beings glory: they bear God's image. Romans 3:23 gives the ruin: all have sinned. Biblical anthropology refuses both flattery and despair.

Human dignity does not depend on wealth, nationality, health, education, usefulness, age, or social standing. The image of God gives every person worth. Yet the image-bearer is fallen; sin affects mind, will, affections, relationships, motives, and conduct.

A strong doctrinal sermon can move through four words: glory, ruin, need, and hope. We are made in God's image; we have fallen; we cannot repair ourselves; God has acted in Christ. Human worth without the cross can become flattery, while human sin without the cross becomes despair.

6. Preaching the Person and Work of Christ

Christian preaching stands or falls with Christ. Jesus is not half God and half man but truly God and truly human. The incarnation is mystery without contradiction: the eternal Son took genuine human nature without ceasing to be God.

The truth preaches through concrete biblical contrasts. As a man he grew tired; as Lord he calls the weary to himself. He thirsted at the cross, yet offers living water. He hungered, yet is the bread of life. He truly died, and he truly rose.

His person cannot be separated from his work. The one who reveals the Father is the one who bears sin, defeats death, rises, reigns, intercedes, and will return. Christology should lead not merely to correct terminology but to faith, worship, assurance, and discipleship.

7. Preaching the Holy Spirit

The Holy Spirit is not an impersonal force but divine Person. He regenerates, indwells, fills, empowers, gives gifts, produces fruit, seals believers, glorifies Christ, and equips the church for witness.

Spirit preaching should avoid two opposite errors: neglecting the Spirit until Christian life sounds self-powered, and speaking of the Spirit in ways detached from Scripture and Christ. The Spirit who inspired the Word does not lead the church away from its truth.

The biblical images are vivid: wind, breath, fire, water, seal. At Pentecost observers even mocked the disciples as drunk; Paul later contrasts drunkenness with being filled by the Spirit. The outward vitality may attract attention, but the source and fruit distinguish the Spirit's work.

8. Preaching Salvation

Salvation is large enough to require many biblical words: grace, faith, repentance, justification, reconciliation, redemption, adoption, regeneration, sanctification, and glorification. A doctrinal preacher explains distinctions without fragmenting the gospel.

One useful sermon structure presents salvation in three tenses. Justification: I have been saved from sin's penalty. Sanctification: I am being saved from sin's power. Glorification: I will be saved from sin's presence.

Philippians 2:12-13 captures the relationship between divine work and human response in sanctification: believers work out what God is working in them. We do not work for acceptance; we live and grow from grace received through faith.

9. Preaching Election, Grace, and the Gospel Call

Election and predestination are biblical words and should not be avoided merely because Christians debate them. But doctrinal preaching should state convictions without caricaturing Christians who read disputed passages differently.

This course emphasizes God's genuine saving desire and the genuine gospel invitation. Second Peter 3:9 and John 3:16 belong beside texts about election. God's foreknowledge should not be turned into a doctrine that portrays him as delighting in the damnation of those who had no genuine opportunity to respond.

The missionary consequence matters. William Carey's famous conflict with hyper-Calvinistic reasoning illustrates the danger of using divine sovereignty to weaken obedience to the Great Commission. Calvinists as well as Arminians have often been vigorous missionaries; the legitimate warning is against any system pushed in a direction that cuts the nerve of evangelism.

Preach election as a reason for gratitude, grace as the ground of salvation, faith as genuine response, and the gospel call as an honest invitation to 'whosoever will.'

10. Preaching the Church

The church is not primarily a building, event, corporation, or audience. It is the people Christ calls, saves, gathers, gifts, and sends. The New Testament pictures it as body, family, flock, temple, bride, and people of God.

Doctrine of the church becomes preach-able when those images become concrete. A body requires interdependence. A family implies belonging and responsibility. A temple speaks of God's presence and holiness. A bride points toward covenant love and hope.

Church doctrine should move beyond attendance toward participation, service, unity, discipline, ordinances, mission, and mutual care. The question is not merely whether I go to church, but how I live as part of Christ's people.

11. Preaching Baptism and the Lord's Supper

Baptism and the Lord's Supper put doctrine into visible action. Christian traditions differ over subjects, mode, sacramental theology, and frequency. The preacher should know the church's convictions while representing other Christians accurately.

Many churches, including Baptists, Pentecostals, and most free churches, practice believer's baptism: baptism follows a credible profession of faith and ordinarily uses immersion portraying identification with Christ in death and resurrection. Other churches, including Lutheran, Reformed, Presbyterian, Methodist, Anglican, and Catholic traditions, also baptize the infants of believing families, understanding baptism as a sign and means of God's grace and covenant promise, with faith to be personally confessed as the child grows. Views of the Lord's Supper likewise range from a memorial understanding to belief in Christ's spiritual or real presence. Most churches agree that the Supper remembers Christ, proclaims his death, calls for self-examination, and expresses fellowship in his body.

Doctrinal preaching around the ordinances should explain what the congregation is doing so that practice does not become unexplained ritual.

12. Preaching Christian Assurance and Security

Assurance asks how believers may know they belong to Christ. The answer should rest first in God's promise and Christ's sufficiency rather than in the fluctuating intensity of religious feeling.

Evangelical Christians hold different convictions about the believer's security, and this course does not require either view. Many teach eternal security: those who are truly born again are kept by God's grace and power and will not finally fall away (John 10:27-29; Romans 8:38-39; Philippians 1:6). Others teach conditional security: believers are kept by the power of God through faith, and the warning passages show that a person can turn away from Christ through persistent unbelief (1 Peter 1:5; Colossians 1:22-23; Hebrews 3:12-14; 6:4-6).

Both positions agree on more than is often noticed. Salvation rests on God's grace and Christ's sufficiency, not on the believer maintaining a perfect record. Neither view may be turned into permission for careless living, and neither may be used to keep tender consciences in constant fear. The doctrinal preacher should represent both views fairly, help hearers study the key texts for themselves, and preach what the New Testament joins together: assurance with calls to perseverance, holiness, self-examination, and growth.

Preach assurance pastorally. Some tender consciences need to hear the strength of God's promise; some presumptuous hearers need to hear that profession without fruit deserves examination. The same doctrine can comfort or awaken depending on the hearer.

13. Preaching Sanctification and Christian Holiness

Sanctification is God's continuing work in believers and their responsive life of obedience. It is neither instant moral perfection nor self-improvement by religious effort.

The New Testament speaks in both indicative and imperative: what God has done and therefore how believers should live. Good holiness preaching preserves that order. Grace does not eliminate commands; it gives them their gospel setting.

Concrete application matters. Holiness concerns speech, sexuality, money, anger, forgiveness, work, family, justice, habits, and love. A sermon that praises holiness without naming life may inspire admiration without change.

14. Preaching Suffering and Providence

Doctrinal preaching becomes especially important when life hurts. Providence confesses that the world is not outside God's care, yet preachers should resist explaining every tragedy as though they had access to God's private reasons.

Job warns against correct-sounding theology applied without wisdom. Romans 8 gives confidence that nothing separates believers from God's love and that God works within the whole story toward redemption; it does not authorize calling evil good.

Preach providence with confidence and humility: God is faithful, suffering is real, lament is biblical, evil remains evil, and Christian hope does not require pretending to know what God has not revealed.

15. Preaching Last Things

Christian eschatology begins with certainties: Christ will return, evil will not have the final word, the dead will be raised, judgment is real, God's people will be with Christ, and creation moves toward God's promised completion.

Christians disagree about the timing and sequence of millennial events and related schemes. A doctrinal sermon can acknowledge premillennial, amillennial, and postmillennial readings without allowing the chart to crowd out the hope.

First John 3:2 points toward the pastoral center: 'we shall be like Him, for we shall see Him as He is.' Eschatology should produce hope, holiness, endurance, mission, and worship rather than speculation or fear.

16. Building the Doctrinal Sermon

Begin with a doctrine that arises from a real biblical text or set of texts. Define it in plain language. Establish it from Scripture. Explain its relationships to other truths. Then ask what difference it makes for worship, belief, conduct, suffering, mission, and hope.

Do not try to preach an entire systematic theology chapter in one sermon. Select one governing idea. A sermon on the Trinity may focus on Christian prayer; a sermon on justification may focus on peace with God; a sermon on resurrection may focus on hope in grief.

Develop the outline rather than merely naming it. Facts inform, but developed images, stories, contrasts, questions, and applications help truth enter memory and life.

17. Illustration Without Distortion

Doctrine often needs illustration because abstract truth can be difficult to grasp. But every analogy has limits. An illustration explains one feature; it does not become the doctrine itself.

Fictional illustrations are legitimate when honestly presented as stories. Jesus used parables. The ethical problem is fiction wearing the costume of historical fact.

Develop an illustration enough for listeners to feel its point, then anchor it to Scripture. A blurb may inform; a story can carry emotional weight. Yet no story, however moving, can establish a doctrine that Scripture does not teach.

18. The Preacher as a Doctrinal Witness

Preaching is not finally something the minister performs; it comes through what the preacher is. Technique matters, but credibility, conviction, love, humility, and spiritual life accompany the words.

Occupy the space. Whether the room holds twenty people or two thousand, take responsibility for reaching the whole room with voice, attention, presence, and concern. This is not mere volume; it is the sense that preacher and congregation inhabit the message together.

You do not give a sermon. You preach from the soul. That truth resists complete description, but congregations recognize the difference between information recited and truth that has first taken hold of the preacher.

19. Controversial Doctrine Without Cowardice or Combat

Doctrinal preaching cannot avoid every disputed subject. The preacher should distinguish central Christian confession from denominational distinctives and from questions on which faithful Christians reasonably differ.

State your conviction honestly. Explain the biblical reasons. Represent alternatives accurately enough that their advocates would recognize them. Do not strengthen your position by weakening someone else's.

Irenic preaching is not uncertain preaching. It can say 'this is what I believe the text teaches' while refusing mockery, fear, or false claims. The goal is truth in love, not victory over an imagined opponent.

20. From Doctrine to Doxology

The natural destination of Christian doctrine is worship. Theology asks what is true; doxology responds to the One who is true. Paul often moves from sustained theological argument into praise.

A sermon on grace should make grace amazing. A sermon on Christ should make Christ precious. A sermon on resurrection should give courage at a grave. A sermon on the Spirit should make dependence on God more natural than self-reliance.

Doctrine that never reaches worship, obedience, hope, love, or mission has stopped too soon. The preacher's task is not to make truth entertaining but to make its biblical glory visible.

Conclusion: Truth With a Pulse

Doctrinal preaching refuses the false choice between theology and life. The great doctrines of Scripture are about the God before whom people live, sin, suffer, hope, die, and rise.

Preach them accurately. Preach them clearly. Develop them until the congregation can see and feel why they matter. Let illustration serve truth, conviction remain charitable, and application grow naturally from doctrine.

The doctrinal sermon has succeeded when people do more than remember a definition—when truth has acquired a pulse in the life of the church.